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The Mende of Sierra Leone

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6. Social Implications of Adult Life

Once initiated in Poro or Sande, the young man and young woman are ready to play their part in the adult life of any Mende community. Thenceforward, however, the course of their lives will run on quite separate, though complementary, lines. In addition to the practical and vocational training received, both sexes are assumed by this time to be familiar with the various social rules and etiquettes of everyday existence and are held responsible, in this respect, for any breach, particularly over marriage and sex laws and the code of hospitality. The former are described in Chapter VII. Etiquette varies in significance according to the circumstances. Generally, all younger persons are expected to show formal deference in addressing their elders of both sexes as well as political superiors. A wife, in approaching her husband, should bend with her hands on her knees, as should children in approaching their father. The men and the older male children take their meals separately and are served first by the women. Only the elderly women take part in religious ceremonies with the men; and Moslem women generally remain on the veranda of the mosque.² In public dances, the men compose one part of the circle, 131 the women and children the other part. It is contrary to etiquette for men and women to walk side by side outside the compound; the man should walk ahead, followed by the woman. It is equally against etiquette for any show of intimacy, other than a hand clasp, to be made in public, even if the parties concerned are lovers. Women should not walk about alone, except on their domestic duties, and particularly not at night. If they do so, they may be referred to as *lete nyahanga*, ('walk-about women'), i.e. prostitutes. There is a strong joking relationship between brother and sister, but a brother who sits on his sister's bed may be held guilty of *simongama* (i.e. incest, see Chapter VII).

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Gender Status

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Etiquette

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Majority

² Except in the 'newer' towns, the sexes customarily separate themselves also at Christian services.

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